defeat? The time was perfect. Attack the enemy when he's at his weakest.

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7 MAY 2021

INDIA | 37,25,991 ACTIVE CASES | 2,43,535 DEATHS | 13.22 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,76,45,313 ACTIVE CASES | 34,17,793 DEATHS | 64.79 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

The media narrative became ruthless towards the Centre and the prime minister. International media groups continuously ran stories projecting him as the chief villain responsible for India's crisis. Stories of efforts made by the government found no place in the narrative, perhaps because averting millions of deaths was simply not as sensational as pictures of mass funerals. While some reporting remained neutral, some was just outright biased and overtly exaggerated. On 28 April, *The Washington Post* published a front-page story which alleged that so many people were dying from the virus that Indians were burning bodies in their backyards.[20] This story was referenced in another story published in *Mail Online* on 25 April.[21] On 30 April, *The Straits Times* also reported that Indians were burning bodies on pavements, backyards, lawns and gardens.[22] All of these stories were inspired from a quote by Karnataka's former chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa, who had agreed to let families bury bodies in a decentralized manner to avoid crowding at cremation grounds in view of the raging second wave of infections.[23] Let me make a stronger case: the issue of overwhelmed cremation grounds was an urban one where the majority of the caseload was concentrated. Urban cities in Karnataka, the state whose chief minister's quote was lifted and where such guidelines were framed did not have homes with backyards and lawns. They were concrete jungles where people lived in compact apartments in buildings constructed very close to each other.

However, due to such unethical journalism, using striking headlines like 'Modi's pandemic choice: Protect his image or protect India. He chose himself'[24], 'India, the world's largest democracy, is now powered by a cult of personality' or Arundhati Roy's 'We are witnessing a crime against